

DIY Ant Control: No Exterminator Required

The Budget Homeowner's Step-by-Step System for Eliminating Ant Infestations Under \$30

Page 1: The Ant Invasion Reality Check

You've been watching them march across your kitchen counter for the third morning in a row. You sprayed. You wiped. You placed traps. They keep coming back.

Here's what no one tells you: the ants you see are worker ants — they don't build the colony, they can't end it. Every can of spray you buy kills the 5% of ants you see and does nothing for the queen and the 95% you're not seeing. The colony keeps reproducing. The invasion continues.

This guide is for homeowners and renters who need to eliminate an ant problem for under \$30. No professional contracts. No monthly services. No vague advice from hardware store employees who are guessing. Just a clear, proven system that works — for most ant species, in most homes, in most situations.

What this guide will NOT do: Guarantee results for carpenter ant damage (you need a professional for that), treat severe structural infestations, or replace professional help for health hazards.

What this guide WILL do: Give you a 14-day elimination protocol that costs under \$30 and works for the most common household ant species.

Page 2: Identify Your Ant Before You Buy Anything

The single biggest mistake homeowners make: treating all ants the same. The treatment that kills odorous house ants does nothing for carpenter ants. The bait that works for pavement ants is ignored by sugar ants. Before you spend a single dollar on treatment, spend five minutes on identification.

The Four Most Common Household Ants:

Odorous House Ant (*Tapinoma sessile*) - What it looks like: Small (2.4-3.2mm), brown to black. When crushed, emits a distinctive rotten coconut or pine smell. - Where it

lives: Wall voids, beneath floors, around hot water pipes. Forms massive colonies with multiple queens. - Why it matters: The most common indoor ant. Colonies can number in the thousands. Spray treatments are nearly useless because the colony fragments and relocates rather than dying. - Treatment: Slow-acting sugar-based bait. Works.

Carpenter Ant (*Camponotus* spp.) - What it looks like: Large (6-12mm), black or reddish-black. Smooth rounded thorax when viewed from the side. - Where it lives: Damp, rotting wood. Unlike termites, they don't eat wood — they excavate it to build nests. - Why it matters: Can cause structural damage over time. A serious carpenter ant problem requires professional assessment. - Treatment: Bait stations can help. Severe infestations need a pro. Do not rely on this guide alone if you see sawdust-like material (frass) near baseboards.

Pavement Ant (*Tetramorium immigrans*) - What it looks like: Small (2-3mm), dark brown to black. Visible ridges (grooves) on the head and body. - Where it lives: Under concrete slabs, in cracks in foundations, under stones. - Why it matters: Nuisance indoors. Can form colonies under your home's foundation. - Treatment: Baits work. Sealing entry points is especially important.

Sugar Ant / Ghost Ant (*Tapinoma melanocephalum* / *Paratrechina longicornis*) - What it looks like: Tiny (1.5-2mm). Ghost ants have a translucent abdomen. Sugar ants vary in color. - Where it lives: Wall voids, behind baseboards, near kitchens. - Why it matters: Strong preference for sweets. Will ignore protein-based baits. - Treatment: Borax-sugar bait (the recipe is in Page 4).

How to identify: Use a phone camera with flash. Get close. Compare to images on the [University of Minnesota Extension Ant ID page](#) or the [NC State Extension Ant ID Guide](#). One clear photo is enough.

Page 3: Find the Entry Points

You can bait and spray all day. If you don't close the entry point, ants will find a new route in. Sealing the entry is half the battle.

How to Find Where Ants Are Getting In:

The flashlight-baiting trick: 1. Wait until the ants are most active (usually morning or evening) 2. Leave a small drop of honey or sugar water on the counter 3. Watch where the ants go after feeding 4. Use a flashlight to follow the trail — ants almost always return to their nest along the same path 5. The entry point is where the trail disappears: a gap in the baseboard, a crack in the window frame, a space under the door

Common Entry Points (ranked by frequency): 1. Gaps under exterior doors — especially the door to the deck or patio 2. Baseboard gaps where floors meet walls 3. Window frames and door frames 4. Pipe penetrations through exterior walls (water, gas, electrical) 5. Bathroom and kitchen vent covers 6. Gaps around clothes dryer exhaust vents

Sealing Entry Points — Under \$10: - **Caulk and backer rod** for gaps larger than 1/4 inch. Load a caulk gun with a \$3 tube of exterior latex caulk and work along baseboards and window frames. - **Draft sweep / door sweep** for under exterior doors. A \$5 self-adhesive draft blocker at the bottom of the door does more than most people expect. - **Vent covers** for bathroom and dryer exhaust vents. Hardware stores carry 4-inch and 6-inch covers for under \$3. - **Steel wool + caulk** for larger gaps (around pipe penetrations). Ants can't chew through steel wool.

Do not use spray foam alone — ants can and do chew through it.

Page 4: The Bait Station Protocol

Here is the core principle: you are not killing the ants you see. You are feeding poison to the colony. The bait must be slow-acting so the worker ants carry it back to the nest and feed it to the queen before it kills them.

Why slow-acting matters: If the bait kills ants instantly, the workers die before they return to the nest. The colony continues. Terro liquid ant baits work because the active ingredient (borax) is slow-acting — workers consume it, return to the nest, and feed it to other workers and the queen.

DIY Borax-Sugar Ant Bait (Cost: under \$5): - 3 tablespoons of sugar - 1 tablespoon of borax (20 Mule Team, available in the laundry aisle) - 10 tablespoons of warm water - Stir until dissolved - Soak cotton balls or small pieces of sponge in the solution - Place in shallow lids, jar caps, or specialized bait stations

Commercial Gel Bait (Cost: \$8-15): - **Terro Liquid Ant Baits** — Pre-filled stations. Works for odorous house ants, sugar ants, ghost ants. Place along ant trails and near entry points. Replace every few days. - **Advion Ant Gel Bait** — Professional-grade. Active ingredient: indoxacarb. Highly effective but requires placing small dots near trails. More targeted than Terro. - **Optigard Ant Gel Bait** — Another professional option. Slower acting than Advion, good for large colonies.

Where to Place Bait Stations: - Along baseboards (not in the middle of the floor where you step) - Near entry points (behind the refrigerator, under the sink) - In

corners of rooms where ant trails converge - NOT near food prep surfaces — use kitchen edges

How Many: Start with 4-6 bait stations. You can add more if you see ants visiting but not enough stations.

The 14-Day Timeline: - Days 1-3: Place bait stations. Ants will find them. Don't interfere. - Days 4-7: Ant activity may briefly increase as more workers discover the bait. This is normal. Do not spray or clean during this window. - Days 8-10: Visible ant activity should begin declining. - Days 11-14: Colony collapse. You should see very few ants. - After Day 14: If ants persist, you have either the wrong bait type (wrong ant species) or a second colony.

Page 5: The 14-Day Protocol in Detail

Day 1 (Set Up): 1. Identify the ant species using the guide in Page 2 2. Find entry points using the flashlight-baiting trick (Page 3) 3. Seal the most accessible entry points with caulk and door sweeps 4. Place bait stations in 4-6 locations 5. Do a general clean: wipe counters, sweep floors, don't leave food exposed

Days 2-3: 6. Check bait stations. Ants should be visiting within 48 hours. 7. If no ants at a station after 2 days, move it to a different location. 8. Resist the urge to spray any ants you see. Leave them alone.

Days 4-7 (Peak Activity): 9. You may see more ants near the bait. This is the colony finding the food and recruiting workers. This is progress. 10. Refill consumed bait stations. 11. If you're seeing ants in a room with no bait station, add one.

Days 8-14 (Decline): 12. Ant numbers should drop noticeably. 13. Continue bait stations until you see zero ants for 3 consecutive days. 14. Remove bait stations. Clean the areas with soapy water.

What If Ants Are Still There After 14 Days? - **Wrong ant species:** Did you identify correctly? Carpenter ants need a different approach. - **Multiple colonies:** Common with odorous house ants. Add more bait stations. - **Bait type mismatch:** Try a protein-based bait if sugar baits aren't working (some ants prefer protein). - **Sealing gap missed:** Repeat the flashlight tracking method at night.

Page 6: Problem Areas — Kitchen and Bathroom

These two rooms are ground zero for most ant invasions. They're warm, they have water, and they have food. Here's how to handle each specifically.

Kitchen: - Store all food in sealed containers. This includes bread, fruit, cereal, and pet food. Ants can smell food through cardboard and plastic bags. - Clean the counters with soapy water every night. Not just wiping — actually clean the surface. - Never leave dirty dishes overnight. This is the single most common kitchen mistake. - Fix dripping faucets. Ants need water. A slow drip under the sink is an ant highway. - Check under the sink carefully. It's dark, warm, and often has moisture. Inspect pipe joints for gaps.

Bathroom: - Fix any leaking faucets or pipes. Ants in bathrooms are usually there for water. - Keep the exhaust fan on during and after showers to reduce humidity. - Remove the bathmat and check underneath it — ants can nest under rubber-backed mats. - Check around the toilet base for gaps in the seal. - Store trash in a sealed container. Bathroom trash cans get used frequently and aren't always thought about as a food source for ants.

The Under-Sink Checklist: - Pull everything out from under the sink - Check for standing water in the cabinet - Inspect pipe entry points — these are common gaps - Seal any gaps with caulk or steel wool - Store cleaning products there, not food items

Page 7: Exterior Perimeter Treatment

You sealed the inside. The ants still exist outside. Without exterior treatment, a new colony will eventually find its way in. This step prevents reinvasion — which is where most people fail.

Exterior Perimeter Basics: - Apply treatment along the foundation wall, 1-2 feet up from the ground - Focus on areas where the foundation meets the soil - Treat around any penetrations through the foundation (pipes, cable lines) - Spray door thresholds and garage entry points

Diatomaceous Earth (DE) — The Natural Option: - Food-grade diatomaceous earth is a powder that cuts through the ant exoskeleton, causing them to dry out - It is non-toxic to humans and pets (but avoid breathing the dust) - Apply in a thin, visible line around the foundation perimeter - Reapply after rain

Perimeter Spray: - If using a liquid spray, apply with a \$15 pump sprayer along the foundation - Ortho Home Defense (available at any hardware store, ~\$12) is labeled for exterior perimeter use - Apply a 2-3 foot band around the entire exterior foundation

Landscaping Considerations: - Ants nest in mulch, decorative stones, and soil that touches the foundation - Keep mulch at least 6 inches from the foundation - Trim back tree limbs and shrubs that touch the house — these create ant highways - Store firewood away from the house, elevated off the ground

Page 8: Long-Term Prevention

You got rid of them. Here's how to keep them from coming back.

Seasonal Maintenance Schedule:

Spring (April-May): - Inspect the exterior for new cracks and gaps - Apply exterior perimeter treatment before ant season heats up - Clean gutters and downspouts — moisture attracts ants - Check weather stripping on all exterior doors

Summer (June-August) — Peak Ant Season: - Monitor bait stations monthly (even if you don't see ants) - Keep kitchen surfaces clean and food sealed - Address any moisture issues immediately (dripping pipes, standing water) - Store pet food in sealed containers, wash bowls daily

Fall (September-October): - Reapply exterior perimeter treatment - Seal any cracks that appeared over the summer - Check window and door weather stripping — replace if brittle

Winter: - Ants are less active but not gone. Continue basic monitoring. - This is the best time for major sealing projects — ants aren't establishing new colonies.

Early Warning Signs of a New Invasion: - Single ants appearing in the kitchen (not yet a full trail) - Ant bodies near windowsills - Sawdust near baseboards (possible carpenter ant activity — act fast)

When to Call the Exterminator: - You see carpenter ant frass (sawdust-like material near wood) - The infestation returns within 30 days of a complete treatment cycle - You have carpenter ants and any signs of wood damage - You've completed two 14-day protocols without success

Page 9: When Your Landlord Won't Help

If you're renting, pest control is often a gray area. Here's how to handle it when your landlord is slow to respond or won't pay for an exterminator.

Your Documentation Checklist: 1. Photos of the ant infestation (ant trails, entry points, affected areas) 2. Dates of first sighting and all communications with landlord 3. Copy of your lease — look for who is responsible for pest control (usually the landlord for common-area infestations) 4. Written communication history (texts, emails) with dates

Tenant Rights by State: - Most states require landlords to maintain habitable living conditions, which includes pest control - Some states have specific timelines for responding to pest complaints (often 14-30 days) - If your landlord refuses to act, you may be able to: - Withhold rent (in some states, with proper procedure) - Pay for treatment yourself and deduct from rent (check local laws) - Contact local housing authority or health department

Low-Cost Options for Renters: - Borax-sugar bait (\$3 for ingredients) works just as well for renters as homeowners - Caulk and steel wool require landlord permission for major sealing work - Request that your landlord seal the entry points — it's in their interest to prevent infestation

Page 10: Next Steps — Your Companion Checklist

Your Bonus — Included

Your printable checklist is ready. It walks through the entire 14-day protocol step by step: identification guide, entry point checklist, bait station placement map, and the daily protocol log.

Your Bonus: Included

This checklist is available in your Lemon Squeezy library. If you purchased this guide, you already have access.

Next Steps: - Download and print the companion checklist PDF — it makes the protocol easier to follow day by day - If you haven't tried the borax-sugar bait yet, start today — the 14-day clock is shorter than you think - Share the ant identification guide with a neighbor who's dealing with the same problem

For Existing Members: Your Lemon Squeezy library has the companion checklist, plus additional resources for other common household pest problems.

Companion Checklist Preview

Week 1 Checklist: - ☐ Day 1: Identified ant species - ☐ Day 1: Located entry points (flashlight-bait method) - ☐ Day 1: Sealed top 3 entry points - ☐ Day 1: Placed 4-6 bait stations - ☐ Days 2-7: Monitored and refilled bait stations - ☐ Day 7: Applied exterior perimeter treatment

Week 2 Checklist: - ☐ Days 8-10: Checked declining ant activity - ☐ Day 10: Assessed whether to continue or pivot - ☐ Day 14: Confirmed zero ant activity for 3 consecutive days - ☐ Day 14: Removed bait stations, cleaned areas - ☐ Day 14: Documented findings for future reference